

Dear Books to Prisoners

Bo-Won Keum

In the summer of 2015—a summer shaped by a tumultuous year of police killings and the growing national discourse on the country’s carceral foundations—I found myself traveling across the US, photographing letters from incarcerated people who wanted to read. It had started the previous winter: every other week, I took a bus to volunteer at a Books Through Bars program in the small city where I lived. By “Books Through Bars,” I mean what has since been termed the “prison book movement,” a diffuse network of operations that solicits and fulfills requests for books from incarcerated people. By “program,” I mean a group of people meeting weekly in a converted garage outfitted with bookshelves and a folding table for opening mail. No more than ten people could fit inside at once. I don’t remember there ever being more than five, including myself. It smelled like an old library because it essentially was one.

The first few packings were slow because letters would stay with me. I would fixate on a single request, particularly those that contained titles or authors I recognized. Titles created a shared language; through them, the edges of the person started to form. Memorable ones included *The Prince*, *The Art of War*, *1984*, *Bird by Bird*, and *Crime and Punishment*, as well as the works of Freud and Nietzsche. Many requests were esoteric, sometimes with the publisher or edition number specified. Others were broader: *Any fiction, please*. Occasionally, the letter would come from someone who had written the program

Images courtesy of Books to Prisoners, a Seattle-based nonprofit organization that mails tens of thousands of free books to people in prisons across the country each year.

previously—the writer would attach a small summary of takeaways from the book they had received, as if for a class.

1

INMATE NAME,
Mr. Keith L. Clark

Florida State Prison
7819 N.W. 228TH STREET
RAIFORD, FLA. 32026,

And, to: whomever, this letter,
may, concerned, when reaches
your facility, may friends
→ yes. I am, Interested in the
LIBRARY donation Project
Program Books for Prisoners
AT your INSTITUTION
ORGANIZATION facility
My Friend,

Page 1 of a ten-page letter written by Keith Clark, incarcerated in Florida State Prison, to Books to Prisoners in 2015.

The most requested books were dictionaries and thesauruses. Other common requests included language textbooks, cookbooks, GED study guides, books on US history, religion, law, crafts, chess and other games, gardening, home improvement, travel magazines of specific geographic regions, and books on how to start and run a business. I started to recognize those who were writing with a sense of renewed commitment to themselves, that familiar surge of determination that propels one to reach out, apply for the job, join the gym, get the library card, sober up. Their modes of address were always the most fastidious and painstakingly polite, dotting all the i's and crossing the t's, paying gross attention to formalities and details. The learned way of speaking after you've been burned hard in life by technicalities. It was rare to match the exact titles requested, as the library's offerings were limited. The selection of thrifted, scavenged, and donated books expressed what the program could afford. Someone who requested *Fifty Shades of Grey* got Edith Wharton instead. *Any fiction, please.*

8

INMATE NAME
Mr. Keith L. Clark

NUMBER-ONE/
Send Me, The - MARXISM
The Political - ECONOMIC
theories of Karl-MARXIST

Number 2# The - Medonna - Virgin Mary,
And the MADAE - A - Title For
A FRENCH WOMAN,
/ With CATALOG MANUAL /
INSTRUCTION / MAN,

Keith Clark for Books to Prisoners, page 8.

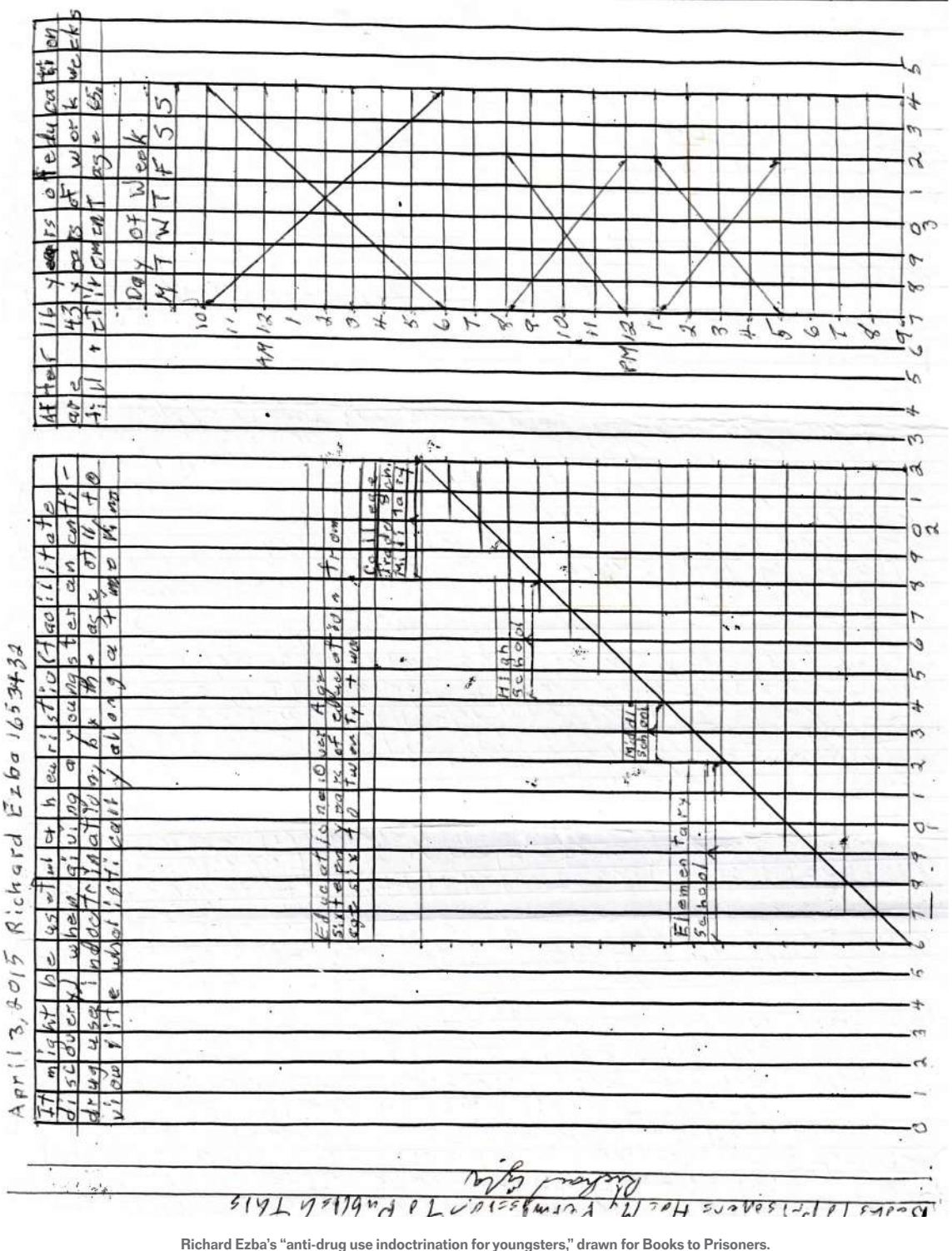
The letters would pile high and fast, so I learned to work faster and manage the waves of emotions that would come with each one. I felt acutely aware that each handwritten letter was an extension of its author, every crease, every smudge a clue, a way to commune with a ghost. I would scan the handwriting, the choice of paper type, the weight of the pen's pressure. Sometimes the evidence aligned into something totalizing, a moment of overwhelming narrative clarity. I remember a letter written in shaky yet deliberately formed schoolbook cursive, the uniform strokes and consistent loops revealing the care with which it was penned. *I am 53 years old, it read, and it has taken me this long to teach myself how to write a simple letter.* Another letter, with a single request, written in title case with double-storey "a's" constructed from an "o" with an open right-angled bracket: *Looking for spelling books in something easy: I Have a Low Eye Q, also need a Big Dictionary.* A request for a Spanish-English dictionary followed by, *I'm a non-English-speaking person, so I'm having my roommate write for me. He is teaching me English.* These flashes of presence would settle in my mind like voices—brief, ten-minute possessions as I searched the stacks, ignited by the

precious feeling of knowing exactly how to be useful.

There were also restrictions on what the facilities themselves could purportedly receive. *Our facility doesn't accept hardcover books. No books with photography, no nudity.* Intent had to be expressed through leaps of faith. I packed an old copy of *Mrs. Dalloway* for a prisoner who wrote that she was queer, hoping for the best. *Inmates in my facility can only receive up to three at a time.* Elie Wiesel, Tennessee Williams, and a writer's handbook from PEN America went to a man facing a life sentence without parole, whose tone was respectful, positive, and asked if we could refer him to a pen-pal program. Sometimes I would open a letter and find a thank you card addressed to the program. I would share it with staff members, and we'd sit with it, knowing that stamps are not cheap for someone who might only be making 52 cents an hour—or no money at all.

Richard Ezba's letter was ten pages long. Richard didn't have any money nor any family or friends who'd paid him visits in the four-and-a-half years he'd been incarcerated at the time of writing, a sixty-six-year-old man and an indigent, to use the government's terms. All he had were the books from these programs. His letter contained a report, complete with diagrams, on the theory of relativity, learned from a former Pentagon supervisor he'd met decades prior. He cited three dictionaries to define the term. He explained space curvatures, black holes, gravitational waves, frame-dragging effects. He referenced *A Brief History of Time*. He enclosed what he called an "anti-drug use indoctrination for youngsters," which was simply a timeline of school from age six to twenty-two, a chart aligning days of the week against hours in the day. The caption: *16 years of education from age 6 to 22.* After 16 years of education are 43 years of work weeks until retirement age 65. He thanked us for the books over the years. He hoped we found his theory as interesting as he did.

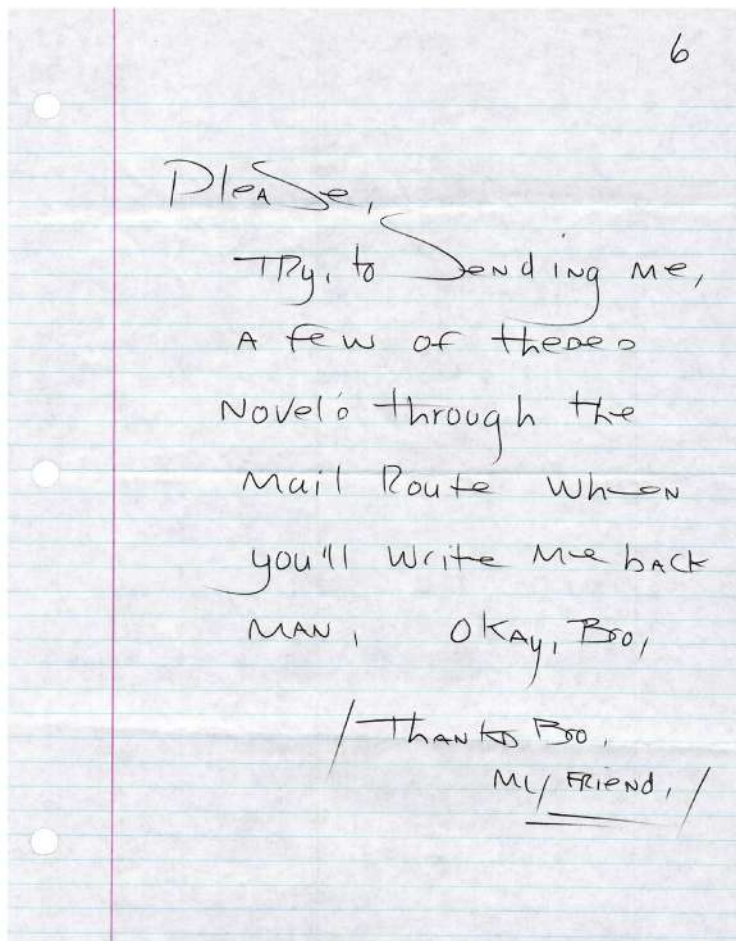
Richard is close to my father in age, the two are probably no more than a year or two apart. My father believed so strongly in the meritocratic power of education that he uprooted an entire family to another country where he didn't speak the language and knew no one in order to send his daughters to the best schools he'd heard of. My father now spends a lot of his retirement taking free Coursera classes he can find from Ivy League schools, dutifully writing 500-word reading responses in his business English on subjects like "philosophy and science" and "Buddhism and modern psychology." Six months ago, he emailed them to my sisters, my mother, and I as a single PDF with the subject line "My Assignments Selected from Coursera," making sure to include the certificate of completion at the end.



Richard Ezba's "anti-drug use indoctrination for youngsters," drawn for Books to Prisoners.

1 Isaac Scher, "A Captive Market," *Jacobin*, January 25, 2020.

2 Gregory Marcinski, "Prison Tablets: Nothing More Than 'Digital Pacifiers,'" *Prison Journalism Project*, July 31, 2024.



Keith Clark for Books to Prisoners, page 6.

I haven't backpacked since the COVID lockdowns, but I know requests have dropped sharply as facilities have tightened restrictions on physical mail, citing security concerns. The vision was to usher in new technology: letters would be scanned and digitized, tablets and e-readers were to replace physical books. Forty-eight out of fifty states now offer tablets, mostly for purchase from private contracting firms. But in 2019, facilities in West Virginia that had been providing their prisoners tablets for free were caught charging users five cents a minute to read.¹ A recent report² from a prisoner in Otisville reveals that despite offering Khan Academy courses and Project Gutenberg, the tablets are loaded with outdated PG-13 movies and simple games, laying bare the motivations behind a policy shift that serves neither education nor reform, but instead a deeper, more unsettling form of erasure. *They gave us a binky, he writes. They just want us to lay down in our bunks and waste our days away.*

One imagines an unbearable weight lifted. Nearly two-million incarcerated people disappear into screens, their letters and their words melt into air. Gone too are these dusty basement libraries, so vulnerable to whims of floods, fires,

their rents contingent on the mercy and good grace of their landlords, and all of these scavenged dollar books carefully selected and packaged in discarded Whole Foods and Trader Joe's paper bags, charged media mail rates to ship at \$2.80 a pound. (The weight of each page in a book begins to matter, here.) Eradicated is the labor of trucking a book a couple of thousand miles to Amarillo, Texas, where a dead-eyed DoC officer, screening the volume for drugs and porn, might just send it back on a power trip, citing violence because the author is Black and has something to say. If this is about giving access to information—which it's not—then turning paper into pixels is surely the solution.

Instead, a different kind of information is lost, not gained—the kind transmitted *through*, and not in spite of, the material conditions of being. Letters hold traces of the hands that write them; a book received in the mail, even one that isn't what was asked for, bears the mark of a fragile but earnest connection. Flares shoot in the dark from separate shores, stuttered signals of life that light up the sky in brief but dazzling displays. These ephemera create the evidence; they are proof that we were present. The people making these policies don't understand that worlds bound by walls need more than information. They need witnesses.

BO-WON KEUM is an independent graphic designer and co-editor of *Dear Books to Prisoners: Letters from the Incarcerated* (2019).